

JAPAN'S NATIONAL TREASURES

Hikone Castle

彦根城 | SHIGA, JAPAN



Built from the borrowed parts of other castles, layered with gables until it looked nothing like a patchwork at all — a guide to the keep that turned salvage into elegance.

THE FIVE NATIONAL TREASURE CASTLES / VOLUME FOUR

Before you go

Admission fees, opening hours and access arrangements described in this book are subject to change. Always check the official website for the latest information before visiting.

Hikone Castle official site: <https://hikonecastle.com/>

Basic Data

At a glance

Name	Hikone Castle (Hikone-jo) — also known as Konki-jo, the Golden Tortoise Castle
Location	1-1 Konkicho, Hikone, Shiga Prefecture
Type	Architecture — the keep, the attached turret and the multi-bay turret are all designated National Treasures
National Treasure	Designated 1952
The keep	Three roofs, three floors over a basement, tower type; about 20.5m including the stone base
Founded	Building began 1603; substantially complete around 1607
Present form	Preserves the early Edo-period castle of Ii Naotsugu and Ii Naotaka
Official site	https://hikonecastle.com/

I How this book is arranged

- ▶ Chapter 1 — History: a keep assembled from seven castles
- ▶ Chapter 2 — Reading the architecture: how a small keep looks this rich
- ▶ Chapter 3 — Walking the castle: a route guide
- ▶ Chapter 4 — Visiting: hours, access, seasons and the neighbourhood

Hikone is the castle that proves a National Treasure does not need a single, unified design. Its buildings were gathered from castles that no longer exist — and the result is one of the most decorative keeps in Japan.

History — a keep assembled from seven castles

| Built by the family of the “Red Devils”

Ii Naomasa distinguished himself at the Battle of Sekigahara and was rewarded with Sawayama, the former domain of Ishida Mitsunari. Naomasa is remembered for the **Ii Red Devils**, the unit that rode into battle in crimson-lacquered armour — but wounds taken at Sekigahara caught up with him, and he died in 1602 before he could build a castle of his own.

It was his eldest son, **Ii Naotsugu**, who chose the new site on Mount Hikone (also called Mount Konki) and began construction in 1603. The castle was substantially complete by around 1607.

| A castle stitched together from moved buildings

What makes Hikone unusual is how many of its buildings carry a tradition of having been **moved here from other castles**:

- **The main keep** — said to have been relocated from Otsu Castle, once held by Kyogoku Takatsugu
- **The Tenbin Turret** — traditionally said to come from Nagahama Castle
- **The Sawaguchi multi-bay turret** (no longer standing) — from Sawayama Castle
- **The western bailey’s triple turret** — from Odani Castle

The **Taiko Gate Turret** is the strangest case of all: when it was dismantled for repair, the timber itself showed it had begun life as the gate of some other castle — but **no one has ever identified which one**. Under the Tokugawa shogunate’s system of shared construction labour, Hikone was finished using material salvaged from the castles being abandoned all around it. That lack of a single, unified origin is exactly what the castle is.



| The Siege of Osaka, and Naotaka

In the winter and summer campaigns of the Siege of Osaka (1614–1615), Naotsugu's younger brother **Ii Naotaka** distinguished himself in the fighting. Headship of the family passed to him as a result, and from then until the Meiji era the Ii family governed Hikone domain as its hereditary lords.

| First threat: scaffolding for demolition, already standing

After the Meiji Restoration, castles across Japan fell under the abolition decree, and Hikone came close to sharing their fate. In 1878, an **imperial progress to the Hokuriku region** brought Emperor Meiji through Hikone — and by this point, tradition holds, **scaffolding for the keep's demolition had already been erected**.

Okuma Shigenobu, who was travelling with the imperial party (some accounts describe him as a distant cousin of the emperor), is said to have urged that the keep be spared. The emperor's decision called the demolition off, and the castle survived.

A note — who really made the case?

Exactly who persuaded the court to save the keep is not fully settled — the Okuma Shigenobu story is the best known, but other versions exist, and the details have never been pinned down. What every account agrees on is the closeness of the call: Hikone, like Himeji, is a castle that survived on the strength of one person's intervention at exactly the right moment.

I Genkyuen, the garden

The keep is not the only thing worth seeing. Around 1677, the fourth lord, **Ii Naooki**, laid out a stroll garden centred on a pond, modelled on the celebrated views of Lake Biwa — the garden known today as **Genkyuen**. It was rebuilt in 1813 as a retirement residence for the eleventh lord, Naonaka, and survives today essentially in that form.



Genkyuen, the pond garden below the castle. The pavilion Hosho-dai stands at the water's edge; on a still day the keep beyond is mirrored in the pond as clearly as it stands. It is included on the same admission ticket as the keep, and is covered again in Chapter 4.

Reading the architecture — small, but this rich

| A dense stack of gables

Hikone's keep has three roofs and three floors — among the smallest of the five National Treasure keeps. And yet the exterior is worked over with an unusually generous mix of **gable forms**: plain gables, hip-and-gable roofs, and curved *karahafu* gables, layered one against another. Ornamental *katomado* windows, with their distinctive flame-shaped profile, appear on the first and second floors. Where Himeji reads as balanced and restrained, Hikone is **a small building made to look busy on purpose** — decoration standing in for scale.

| The Tenbin Turret — cut the bridge, and the keep stands alone

The main bailey is guarded by the **Tenbin Turret**. A bridge crosses a dry moat cut into the hillside and leads to a pair of matching two-storey turrets joined by a long connecting turret — a shape that, seen from the front, resembles a set of balance scales, which gives the turret its name. Cut the bridge and the dry moat isolates the main bailey completely, stalling any attacker in their tracks. **A perfectly symmetrical design that is also a working piece of defence** — this is the single feature at Hikone most worth stopping for.



The Tenbin Turret seen head-on, across the bridge that crosses the dry moat. Remove the bridge and the two halves of the turret — and the bailey behind them — are cut off from each other entirely.

| The character of a castle built from spare parts

As Chapter 1 described, Hikone's buildings each carry their own history. Where Himeji was designed from the ground up under one coherent plan, Hikone is **an assembly of parts gathered from castles across the region**. The keep, the Tenbin Turret and the Taiko Gate Turret each wear a slightly different face precisely because of where they came from. That **mismatched parts were made to function as a single working castle** is, in itself, a demonstration of just how far the craft of castle-building had advanced.

| A rare, nearly complete picture of an Edo-period castle

Most surviving Japanese castles have kept only a keep, or a keep and a turret or two — the surrounding buildings and moats are almost always gone. Hikone still has its keep, attached turret and multi-bay turret, and beyond them the **Tenbin Turret, Taiko Gate Turret and the western bailey's triple turret** — all designated Important Cultural Properties — along with an **almost intact inner and middle moat**. The castle's stables, too, survive: a rare example of a castle stable still standing anywhere in Japan. Taken together, Hikone is one of the few places that still shows an Edo-period castle as it actually was — **not just a keep, but a moated, turreted, gardened town in miniature**.



The stable (*umaya*), an Important Cultural Property and the only castle stable of its kind still standing in Japan. It is easy to walk past looking only for the keep — but buildings like this are what make Hikone's surviving townscape so unusual.

Walking the castle

- ▶ Omotemon Bridge — enter here
- ▶ The Tenbin Turret — the dry moat and the bridge
- ▶ The Taiko Gate Turret — the gate into the main bailey
- ▶ The main bailey and the keep — basement to third floor
- ▶ The western bailey's triple turret
- ▶ Kuromon Gate
- ▶ Genkyuen — the garden with the keep in view

Plan	Time	What you see
Keep only	About 1 hour	Omotemon Bridge to the keep to Kuromon Gate
Standard	1.5-2 hours	Keep plus Genkyuen
Unhurried	2-3 hours	All of the above plus Hikone Castle Museum

Before you set off

The stairs inside the keep are **steep**, so wear shoes you can climb in and carry a bag that leaves both hands free. Hikonyan, the castle's mascot, appears within the grounds three times a day — check the official website for the current schedule and locations.

What not to miss

- **The Tenbin Turret** — the symmetrical turret seen across the bridge over the dry moat
- **The keep's gables** — watch for the layered plain, hip-and-gable and curved gables
- **The keep from Genkyuen** — the keep mirrored across the pond, Hikone's finest view
- **The Taiko Gate Turret** — worth a longer look once you know its origin is a mystery

| Along the way



The Taiko Gate Turret, the gate into the main bailey, framed by pine and stonework. Somewhere in its timbers is proof it once belonged to another castle — a castle whose name is now lost.

Every gate on the way to the keep asks something different of you — a bridge here, a turn there. By the time the keep itself comes into view above the Taiko Gate Turret, you have already walked through most of what made this castle hard to attack.



The middle moat, with a turret and corner tower beyond the water, seen from Omotemon Bridge. Much of Hikone's moat survives intact — a rarer sight among Japan's castles than the keep itself.

Visiting

Admission

Open	8:30–17:00 (last admission 16:30)
Admission	1,000 yen for adults (high school age and above); 300 yen for primary and middle school students
Access inside	Open year-round; the interior of the keep can be visited. Genkyuen garden is included on the same grounds
Official site	https://hikonecastle.com/

Fees and hours change. Please check the official website before you travel.

Getting there

Nearest station	JR Hikone Station
On foot	About 15 minutes from the station's west exit
By car	Paid car parks nearby
By train	About 5 minutes by JR from Maibara Station to Hikone Station

The castle through the year

Spring	Cherry blossom against the keep; fresh green in Genkyuen too
Summer	Deep green along the moat set against the keep
Autumn	Autumn colour in Genkyuen; the keep mirrored in the pond is the season's best sight
Winter	Clear air sharpens the layered gables of the keep

I Nearby

Genkyuen (Chapter 1) is included on the same admission ticket and is the natural pairing with the castle itself. Beyond it, the museum and the reconstructed castle-town street of Yume Kyobashi are both an easy walk from the main gate.



Hikone Castle Museum, a reconstruction of part of the lord's residence. It holds the armour and art of the Ii family — including pieces from the Red Devils themselves.



Beckoning cats on Yume Kyobashi Castle Road, the reconstructed shopping street just outside Kyobashi. Hikonyan, the castle's own mascot, began life as a version of this figure.

- **Yume Kyobashi Castle Road** — white-walled, black-latticed shopfronts built to evoke the Edo-period castle town
- **Yobancho Square** — a small enclave of Taisho-era Western-style buildings

I Local food

- **Omi beef** — Shiga Prefecture's celebrated brand of beef, served across the town
- **Red konjac** — a Shiga speciality, coloured red with iron oxide, with a firm texture and none of konjac's usual sharpness
- **Hikone-don** — a local rice bowl combining simmered Omi beef offcuts with red konjac

For a second visit

The Taiko Gate Turret's hidden origin, the exact join where a moved building meets one built on site — these are details easiest to notice once you already know the story. A second walk through the castle, guided by Chapter 1, tends to reveal far more than the first.

Credits and notes

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Principal sources

Hikone Castle official site — <https://hikonecastle.com/>

Cultural Heritage Online (Agency for Cultural Affairs) — <https://online.bunka.go.jp/>

City of Hikone (tourism and culture pages)

Japan's National Treasures — Hikone Castle

The Five National Treasure Castles, Volume Four

Only five castle keeps in Japan are designated National Treasures:

Himeji, Matsumoto, Inuyama, Hikone and Matsue. This series visits each of them in turn.